

ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS

Membership Recruitment Guide



A Practical Guide to Finding, Meeting, and Welcoming New Seekers

Love • Wisdom • Harmony • Truth

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1. PURPOSE OF THIS GUIDE

Every healthy lodge needs new members. New members bring new friendships, new ideas, new skills, new energy, and the ability to carry the traditions of Free Gardenery into another generation.

Recruiting does **not** require sales experience, a large personality, or the ability to give a perfect speech.

If you can:

- talk to someone,
- tell them why you enjoy being a Free Gardener,
- invite them to an event,
- answer a few basic questions, and
- introduce them to other members,

you can recruit.

The purpose of this guide is to teach every member of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners how to comfortably introduce the Order to people in their community.

The basic philosophy is simple:

Meet people. Build relationships. Share our story. Extend an invitation.

Recent fraternity recruitment research strongly supports this relationship-centered approach. A 2025 survey of more than 4,200 potential fraternity members found that personal relationships were still the most important routes into fraternity life: 38% first learned about recruitment from an existing member, 34% from another friend considering membership, and 31% through family or family friends. Friendship, fun, belonging, networking, and leadership were among the strongest reasons for considering membership.

The lesson for Free Gardeners is important:

People usually join organizations because someone they know or trust invited them to take a closer look.

2. WHAT ARE WE REALLY RECRUITING PEOPLE TO?

Before attempting to recruit anyone, a member must be able to explain what the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners is in ordinary language.

Do not begin with degrees, titles, regalia, passwords, or complicated history.

Begin with **purpose**.

The Ancient Order of Free Gardeners traces its tradition to seventeenth-century Scotland, where gardeners organized lodges to share knowledge, assist one another, and cultivate both the earth and personal character. Modern Free Gardenerly continues that tradition through fraternity, personal development, symbolism, education, fellowship, and community service.

The Order teaches the principles of:

Love — caring for others.

Wisdom — continuing to learn and improve.

Harmony — living and working peacefully with others.

Truth — developing integrity and sincerity.

The gardening tradition provides a simple metaphor for the entire organization:

Just as a garden must be cultivated to grow, so must the individual.

Members learn through fellowship, lectures, discussions, symbolic degree ceremonies, service, and participation in lodge life. The degrees progress through Apprentice Gardener, Journeyman Gardener, and Master Gardener, reflecting the traditional stages of the gardening craft.

3. THE FIRST RULE OF RECRUITMENT

Do Not Recruit Strangers. Make Strangers Acquaintances.

A common mistake is imagining recruitment as walking up to someone and immediately asking:

“Would you like to join my fraternity?”

That approach can feel uncomfortable for both people.

Instead, think of recruitment as a series of small steps:

Meet → Talk → Connect → Invite → Inform → Follow Up → Ask

You do not need to complete every step during the first conversation.

Recruitment begins with a relationship.

4. EVERY MEMBER IS A RECRUITER

A lodge may have a Membership Committee or Membership Chair, but recruitment should never belong only to one officer.

Every member knows people the lodge does not know.

Think about:

- friends;
- relatives;
- coworkers;
- neighbors;
- former classmates;
- people from civic organizations;
- members of gardening clubs;
- people involved with community gardens;
- conservation volunteers;
- local historians;
- educators;
- nonprofit volunteers;
- faith-community acquaintances;
- people interested in philosophy or symbolism;
- people interested in fraternal history;
- people you regularly see at community events;
- friends of current members.

You already have a potential recruitment network.

You simply may never have thought about it that way.

5. THE SIMPLE “FIVE-NAME” EXERCISE

A new recruiter should begin here.

Write down five people you know who might appreciate:

1. meaningful friendship;
2. personal growth;
3. community service;
4. history and tradition;
5. gardening, nature, conservation, or symbolism.

Do **not** immediately decide whether they would join.

Your responsibility is only to determine whether they might enjoy **learning more**.

Your first goal is not:

“Get five people to join.”

Your first goal is:

“Invite five people to discover the Order.”

That is much easier.

6. WHAT MAKES A GOOD POTENTIAL MEMBER?

Do not recruit simply to increase numbers.

Look for people who could contribute positively to lodge life.

Good prospects may demonstrate:

- kindness;
- reliability;
- curiosity;
- integrity;
- willingness to learn;
- interest in helping others;
- respect for tradition;
- interest in personal improvement;
- ability to work with different personalities;
- commitment to community;
- willingness to participate.

Modern fraternity recruitment guidance increasingly emphasizes **values-based recruitment**: organizations should seek people whose values align with their purpose rather than simply trying to produce the largest possible class.

Ask yourself:

Would I enjoy sitting beside this person at a lodge meeting?

Would I trust this person to work beside me on a service project?

Could this person someday help strengthen the lodge?

If the answers are yes, get to know them better.

7. HOW TO START THE CONVERSATION

Never feel that you need to deliver a speech.

Use ordinary conversation.

Example 1 — Someone notices your emblem

Them: “What does that symbol mean?”

You:

“It belongs to an old fraternal tradition called the Free Gardeners. We use gardening as a symbol for improving ourselves and helping our communities.”

Stop.

Let them respond.

If they say:

“That sounds interesting.”

Continue.

You:

“Our tradition goes back centuries. Today we combine fellowship, personal development, history, service, and the symbolism of gardening. I’ve really enjoyed being part of it.”

Then:

“If you’re curious, I can send you our website.”

8. QUICK ELEVATOR PITCHES

Members should learn the idea behind these pitches rather than memorizing every word.

10-Second Pitch

“The Ancient Order of Free Gardeners is a historic fraternity focused on friendship, personal growth, service, and the idea that we should cultivate ourselves the same way we cultivate a garden.”

20-Second Pitch

“The Free Gardeners are a centuries-old fraternal tradition that began among working gardeners in Scotland. Today we use the symbolism of gardening to teach personal growth while building genuine friendships, learning together, and serving our communities.”

30-Second Pitch

“The Ancient Order of Free Gardeners is a historic fraternal organization with roots going back to seventeenth-century Scotland. Gardening is both part of our heritage and a metaphor for life. We believe that just as a garden needs patience and cultivation, people do too. Our lodges bring

people together for fellowship, education, personal development, tradition, and community service.”

Intrigue Pitch

“Imagine an old fraternity where the tools and lessons of gardening are used to teach you how to cultivate your own life. That’s essentially Free Gardenery.”

Community-Service Pitch

“We’re a fraternity that believes tending the community is just as important as tending the garden. Our members come together for fellowship, personal growth, and projects that improve the communities around us.”

History Pitch

“The Free Gardeners are one of the lesser-known historic fraternal traditions. Our recorded history reaches back to Scotland in the 1600s. The organization evolved from working gardeners into a fraternity that uses gardening to teach lessons about life and character.”

Personal Pitch

“I joined because I wanted something that combined genuine fellowship with history, symbolism, learning, and service. It turned out to be very different from what most people imagine when they hear the word fraternity.”

9. THE BEST RECRUITMENT QUESTION

Instead of asking:

“Do you want to join?”

begin with:

“Would you be interested in learning more?”

That question is comfortable.

There is no pressure.

The person can say yes without feeling that they have committed themselves to membership.

Once someone expresses interest, invite them to an appropriate public event, informational meeting, service project, or casual conversation.

10. TALKING POINTS EVERY MEMBER SHOULD KNOW

You do not have to explain everything about the Order.

Focus on six points.

1. History

Free Gardenery traces its documented history to Scotland in the seventeenth century.

2. Personal Growth

Gardening provides a metaphor for improving one's character, knowledge, relationships, and life.

3. Fellowship

The lodge provides a community in which people can form friendships that go beyond meetings.

4. Education

Members explore history, symbolism, philosophy, gardening traditions, and metaphorical gardening through lodge instruction, lectures, and discussions.

5. Service

Free Gardeners are encouraged to support community gardens, conservation, beautification, stewardship of nature, and projects that strengthen their communities.

6. Tradition

The Order uses degrees, ceremonies, symbols, and traditions to teach moral lessons and connect today's members with generations of Free Gardeners who came before them.

11. WHAT NOT TO DO

Recruitment should never feel desperate, deceptive, or aggressive.

Never:

- pressure someone to apply;
- argue with someone who is not interested;
- promise that an applicant will be accepted;
- exaggerate the benefits of membership;
- hide legitimate membership responsibilities;
- insult other fraternities or organizations;
- reveal private ritual material;
- make the organization sound frighteningly secretive;

- promise professional connections or financial benefits;
- recruit someone only because the lodge “needs numbers”;
- repeatedly contact someone who has clearly declined.

Most importantly:

Do not turn every conversation into a sales pitch.

Recruitment should feel natural.

12. ANSWERING “IS IT A SECRET SOCIETY?”

A simple response is best:

“We’re a fraternal organization with some private ceremonies and traditions, like many historic fraternities. But who we are, what we believe, our history, and our community activities aren’t secret. You can learn quite a bit about us through our website.”

Do not make secrecy the attraction.

Mystery may create curiosity, but **purpose creates commitment.**

13. ANSWERING “WHAT DO YOU ACTUALLY DO?”

Say:

“We meet as a lodge for fellowship, education, and the business of the organization. We also have lectures and discussions, community-service activities, social events, and degree ceremonies that use gardening symbolism to teach lessons about personal growth.”

Then personalize it:

“My favorite part has been _____.”

Personal stories are more memorable than organizational descriptions.

14. ANSWERING “HOW MUCH DOES IT COST?”

Be transparent.

Under the Order’s current published membership information, there is no Order-level fee to join. Local lodges may establish annual lodge dues, and new members are responsible for required regalia.

A recruiter can say:

“The Order doesn’t currently charge a joining fee. A local lodge may have annual dues, and members are responsible for their required regalia. Before you apply, we’ll explain any local costs clearly so you know exactly what to expect.”

Never avoid questions about money.

Recent recruitment research shows cost and time commitments remain significant concerns for potential members. Clear answers build trust.

15. ANSWERING “HOW MUCH TIME DOES IT TAKE?”

Do not say:

“Hardly any.”

Instead say:

“It depends on how involved you want to become. There are lodge meetings and activities, but members have different work and family schedules. We want people to participate meaningfully without pretending that everyone has unlimited free time.”

Then explain your lodge’s actual meeting schedule.

16. BUSINESS CARDS: THE SIMPLEST RECRUITMENT TOOL

Every active member should consider carrying several small AOFG information cards.

The card is not supposed to explain the entire organization.

Its purpose is to move someone from:

Curious → Website Visitor

Suggested Front

ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS

Cultivate Yourself.

Cultivate Community.

Love • Wisdom • Harmony • Truth

[AOFG EMBLEM]

Suggested Back

Discover Free Gardenery

A centuries-old tradition of:

Fellowship • Personal Growth • Service • Tradition

Scan to Learn More

[QR CODE]

thefreegardeners.org

Optional line:

Ask me why I became a Free Gardener.

17. USING THE QR CODE

The QR code should lead directly to the AOFG website or, when available, a dedicated membership information page.

QR codes can be placed on:

- business cards;
- brochures;
- bookmarks;
- table displays;
- event flyers;
- banners;
- information folders;
- lodge newsletters;
- posters;
- name badges at public events.

Digital membership pathways are increasingly important in contemporary lodge recruitment. Current Masonic recruitment resources specifically encourage organizations to combine personal contact with websites, online inquiries, social media, flyers, banners, and other easy “front doors” into membership.

The QR code does **not** replace the conversation.

The conversation creates curiosity.

The QR code makes the next step easy.

18. RECRUITING THROUGH COMMUNITY SERVICE

One of the best ways to recruit is not to hold a recruitment event at all.

Hold a **service event**.

Invite nonmembers to work beside you.

Examples include:

- community garden workdays;
- park cleanups;
- planting flowers at a school;
- neighborhood beautification;
- tree planting;
- food-growing projects;
- seed giveaways;
- conservation projects;
- helping maintain a historic cemetery or public garden;
- supporting a local community garden;
- neighborhood cleanup days.

Wear tasteful AOFG shirts, hats, or badges.

Have business cards available.

Place a small sign at the project:

ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS

Cultivating a Better World

Ask Us About Free Gardenerly

[QR CODE]

This allows people to **see the Order's values before hearing about them**.

Current Elks membership guidance similarly encourages lodges to invite guests to charitable activities, publicize their community projects, provide informational materials, and personally invite interested guests to learn about membership.

19. SIMPLE INFORMATIONAL EVENTS

Recruitment events do not need to be expensive.

In fact, informal events often create better conversations.

Modern fraternity recruitment guidance recommends conversation-based, low-pressure events where members and prospects can actually learn about one another.

Idea 1 — Coffee With the Free Gardeners

Reserve several tables at a local coffee shop.

Invite 5–10 potential Seekers.

No presentation is necessary.

Members simply talk with guests about the Order.

Cost: Very low.

Length: 45–60 minutes.

Idea 2 — Meet the Free Gardeners

Host a public informational evening at:

- a library;
- community center;
- garden center;
- lodge meeting space;
- restaurant meeting room.

Provide a short presentation followed by conversation.

Idea 3 — History of the Free Gardeners

Give a 20–30 minute public presentation on the history of Free Gardenerly.

Topics might include:

- seventeenth-century Scottish gardening lodges;
- operative and speculative Free Gardenerly;
- historic gardening tools and symbolism;
- the modern revival of the tradition.

History becomes the introduction to membership.

Idea 4 — Garden & Grow

Host a simple gardening workshop.

Possible topics:

- container gardening;

- starting seeds;
- composting;
- native plants;
- herb gardens;
- pollinator gardens.

Conclude with five minutes explaining why gardening has symbolic importance to Free Gardeners.

Idea 5 — Community Garden Day

Partner with an existing community garden.

Invite friends and prospective members to work beside lodge members.

Finish with refreshments and informal conversation.

Idea 6 — Philosophy in the Garden

Host an informal discussion around questions such as:

“What does it mean to cultivate a good life?”

“What weeds do we sometimes need to remove from our own lives?”

“What can gardening teach us about patience?”

Then explain that metaphorical gardening is part of the Free Gardener tradition.

Idea 7 — Bring a Friend Night

Ask every member to bring **one person** to a casual lodge social.

No one should be required to bring a guest.

A gathering of eight members bringing five guests is already a successful recruitment event.

Idea 8 — Virtual Information Night

Host a 30–45 minute Zoom session.

Suggested title:

“What Is Free Gardener?”

This is especially useful for individuals who do not live near an established lodge.

20. HOW TO HOST A ONE-HOUR INFORMATION NIGHT

You do not need a complicated program.

Before the Event

Prepare:

- AOFG banner or sign;
- lodge emblem;
- business cards;
- QR code;
- simple sign-in sheet;
- name tags;
- water or light refreshments;
- one-page information sheet.

Invite prospects personally.

Do not rely solely on posting a flyer.

Suggested Agenda

0:00–0:10 — Welcome

Greet everyone individually.

Members should spread out and talk with guests instead of standing together.

0:10–0:15 — Opening

Host says:

“Thank you for joining us. Tonight isn’t an application meeting and nobody is expected to make a decision. We simply want to introduce you to Free Gardenerly, tell you why we became involved, and give you an opportunity to ask questions.”

This immediately reduces pressure.

0:15–0:25 — What Is Free Gardenerly?

Briefly explain:

- history;
- purpose;
- Love, Wisdom, Harmony, and Truth;
- metaphorical gardening;

- lodge fellowship;
- service.

Keep it under ten minutes.

0:25–0:35 — Member Stories

Ask three members to speak for two or three minutes each.

Questions:

- Why did you join?
- What surprised you?
- What do you enjoy most?
- What has membership taught you?

0:35–0:45 — Lodge Life

Explain:

- meetings;
- educational programs;
- fellowship;
- service;
- degree progression;
- general membership process.

Do not reveal private ritual details.

0:45–0:55 — Questions

Allow guests to ask anything.

If you do not know an answer, say:

“I don’t know, but I’ll find out.”

0:55–1:00 — Invitation

Close with:

“If what you’ve heard tonight interests you, we’d be glad to continue the conversation. Scan the QR code, visit the website, or speak with any member here. There’s no pressure to apply tonight. We simply invite you to explore whether Free Gardenery might be right for you.”

21. COLLECT CONTACT INFORMATION

A good event means little if nobody follows up afterward.

Use a simple voluntary sign-in sheet:

Name

Email

Phone

How did you hear about us?

Would you like information about membership? YES / NO

Would you like information about future public events? YES / NO

Do not add someone to ongoing messages without appropriate permission.

22. FOLLOW-UP: WHERE RECRUITMENT IS OFTEN LOST

This may be the most important part of this guide.

A person attends.

They enjoy themselves.

They give you their contact information.

Then nobody contacts them.

The opportunity disappears.

A current Scottish Rite membership study highlights how serious this problem can become: its recruitment guidance reports that a large majority of online inquiries in its broader Masonic pipeline had historically received no local follow-up. Its recommendations therefore emphasize assigning responsibility, tracking inquiries, communicating personally, and measuring response time.

AOFG lodges should establish a simple standard:

Every inquiry belongs to someone.

Assign a member to every interested person.

23. THE 48-HOUR RULE

As an AOFG best practice, contact interested people within **48 hours** whenever practical.

The message should not be:

“Have you decided whether you’re joining?”

It should sound human.

Example

“Hi James, this is Marcus from the Free Gardeners. I enjoyed talking with you Saturday, especially our conversation about community gardening. I just wanted to thank you for coming. If you have any questions about the Order, feel free to reach out anytime.”

Recent fraternity recruitment guidance similarly emphasizes that meaningful follow-up should show that the recruiter remembered the person and the conversation rather than treating the prospect like a transaction.

24. A SIMPLE FOLLOW-UP SCHEDULE

First Contact

Within 48 hours.

Thank them.

Second Contact

Approximately one week later.

Share something relevant to their interests.

Examples:

- upcoming service event;
- historical article;
- public lodge activity;
- lecture;
- AOFG website page.

Third Contact

Invite them personally to something.

“Several of us are meeting for coffee Saturday. You’re welcome to join us.”

Fourth Contact

If their interest continues:

“From the conversations we’ve had, it sounds like you might enjoy membership. Would you like me to explain the application process?”

Now the invitation feels natural.

25. KEEP A SIMPLE PROSPECT LIST

A spreadsheet is enough.

Track:

Name	Introduced By	Interest	Last Contact	Next Step
Alex	Jordan	History	Aug. 10	Invite to lecture
Marcus	David	Service	Aug. 12	Community garden
Chris	Website	Fellowship	Aug. 15	Coffee meeting

Possible stages:

NEW CONTACT

LEARNING

ATTENDED EVENT

INTERESTED

APPLICATION

PAUSED

NOT INTERESTED

Never shame someone for choosing not to proceed.

26. RECRUITING AT COMMUNITY EVENTS

A lodge may participate in:

- festivals;
- garden shows;
- farmers markets;
- heritage festivals;
- volunteer fairs;

- Earth Day events;
- community days;
- historic society events;
- environmental fairs;
- nonprofit expos.

Your Table Should Have

- clean tablecloth;
- AOFG emblem;
- one banner;
- QR code;
- business cards;
- simple brochure;
- photographs of real lodge activities;
- upcoming-event flyer.

Avoid covering the table with regalia or unexplained symbols.

The table should answer:

WHO ARE YOU?

WHAT DO YOU DO?

WHY SHOULD I CARE?

HOW DO I LEARN MORE?

27. THE TABLE CONVERSATION

Do not sit behind the table staring at your phone.

Stand when possible.

Smile.

Say:

“Hello! Have you ever heard of the Free Gardeners?”

If they say no:

“Most people haven’t. We’re actually part of a fraternal tradition going back to Scotland in the 1600s.”

Now you have curiosity.

Follow with:

“We use gardening both literally and symbolically as a way of talking about personal growth, service, and community.”

Then allow them to ask questions.

28. SOCIAL MEDIA IS THE SUPPORTING TOOL

Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, and other platforms can introduce the organization, but they should support—not replace—personal relationships.

The strongest recruitment content shows **real activity**.

Post photographs of:

- service projects;
- community gardens;
- educational lectures;
- fellowship events;
- public ceremonies;
- workshops;
- lodge outings;
- historical research;
- conservation projects.

Avoid making the social-media page look like nothing happens except formal meetings.

Prospective members should be able to imagine themselves participating.

Current fraternity research suggests social media remains useful, but personal recommendations and relationships continue to have greater influence over joining decisions.

29. SHOW — DON'T JUST TELL

Instead of posting:

“We believe in service.”

Post:

“This morning members of Evergreen Lodge spent three hours preparing garden beds for the neighborhood community garden.”

Instead of:

“We value fellowship.”

Show members eating together after a project.

Instead of:

“We value education.”

Show a photograph of a guest lecturer.

People understand organizations through stories and experiences.

30. THREE QUESTIONS THAT CREATE GOOD CONVERSATIONS

When speaking with a potential Seeker, ask:

“What kinds of organizations or activities are you involved with?”

This reveals interests.

“What do you enjoy doing in the community?”

This reveals motivations.

“What would you want from an organization like this?”

Then listen.

Do not spend the entire conversation talking about yourself.

Recruitment is partly discovering whether **the Order fits the person and the person fits the Order.**

31. INVITING SOMEONE TO APPLY

Eventually, someone must actually extend the invitation.

Current lodge membership guidance makes this point clearly: organizations can host excellent open houses and community events and still lose potential members simply because nobody actually asks them to join.

When you believe someone is genuinely interested, say:

“You’ve spent some time getting to know us, and we’ve enjoyed getting to know you. I think you could be a good addition to the lodge. If you’re interested, I’d be happy to show you how to apply.”

Simple.

No dramatic sales pitch.

32. EXPLAINING THE NEXT STEP

The current AOFG public membership process explains that an interested person submits an application, which is reviewed by the lodge. The lodge may arrange a discussion regarding the applicant's interest before voting. If approved, the candidate receives an invitation to the Apprentice Degree.

Explain this clearly.

Never imply:

"Fill this out and you're automatically a member."

Instead:

"The application begins the process. Membership is considered by the lodge."

33. RECRUITMENT IS ALSO RETENTION

The recruitment process creates expectations.

If we recruit using:

- friendship,
- education,
- service,
- meaningful discussion,
- personal development,

then lodge life should actually provide those things.

A potential member should not encounter one organization during recruitment and a completely different organization after initiation.

Modern fraternity recruitment guidance therefore treats recruitment and new-member integration as connected processes rather than ending recruitment the moment someone accepts membership.

The best recruiter is ultimately:

A good lodge.

When members are active, learning, serving, laughing, and enjoying one another's company, recruitment becomes much easier.

34. THE ONE-PERSON-A-YEAR GOAL

Every lodge does not need every member to recruit ten people.

Imagine a lodge of twelve members.

If every member introduces **one qualified new member during an entire year**, the lodge could potentially double.

That makes the individual challenge simple:

Find one person this year who deserves to discover Free Gardenery.

Not ten.

Not twenty.

One.

35. THE MONTHLY RECRUITMENT HABIT

At each lodge meeting, spend five minutes asking:

Who did we meet?

Who attended an event?

Who needs follow-up?

Who should we invite next?

Recruitment should be a normal part of lodge activity, not an emergency project started when membership becomes low.

36. A SIMPLE 30-DAY RECRUITMENT CHALLENGE

Week One — Identify

Every member writes down five potential prospects.

Week Two — Connect

Have a conversation with at least two.

Do not ask them to join.

Simply mention the Order naturally.

Week Three — Invite

Invite at least one person to:

- coffee;
- service project;
- public event;
- lodge social;
- informational meeting.

Week Four — Follow Up

Contact the person afterward.

Ask:

“What did you think?”

That is recruitment.

37. THE RECRUITER’S POCKET CARD

Every member should remember:

FIND

Who would appreciate our values?

TALK

Start a normal conversation.

LISTEN

Learn about the person.

SHARE

Explain what Free Gardenerly means to you.

INVITE

Bring them to something.

FOLLOW UP

Show that the relationship matters.

ASK

When the time is appropriate, invite them to consider membership.

38. FINAL MESSAGE TO THE RECRUITER

You do not need to convince everyone to become a Free Gardener.

You only need to help the right people **discover that Free Gardenerly exists.**

Some will be curious.

Some will attend an event.

Some will decide it is not for them.

Some will become members.

And among those members may be a future Master Gardener, lodge officer, community leader, lecturer, mentor, or founder of a lodge that does not yet exist.

Every lodge began because someone invited someone else into the garden.

Our responsibility is to continue planting those seeds.

Cultivate the individual.

Cultivate the lodge.

Cultivate the community.

Love • Wisdom • Harmony • Truth